



A SOOTHEMADE BOOK

The Field Guide to Asking for Help

*Thirty scripts for asking specific people for
specific help.*

Soothemade

A SMALL APOTHECARY · MADE SLOWLY

Dedication

For the friend who never asks. The parent who carries it alone. The caregiver who is one favor away from collapse.

You were always allowed to ask.

A note from Maya

I lived for years under the assumption that the right way to be a friend was to never need anything. I was generous with my own help. I was bad at the other side of that math.

It took me a postpartum stretch I could not get through alone to admit it. By then I had a body that was healing, two kids who needed something every nine minutes, a partner who was also tapped out, and an inbox full of "let me know if you need anything" texts I had not figured out how to answer.

The truth I learned: "let me know if you need anything" is the most useless offer in the language. It puts the asking on the exhausted person. The right shape of help is a specific person doing a specific thing at a specific time. The asker is the one who closes that loop.

This book is the words for closing the loop. Thirty scripts across the eight categories of help most people need and almost never ask for. Meals. Childcare. Eldercare. Errands. Emotional support. Money. Home help. The visit where someone just sits with you.

It is the companion to *30 Scripts for the Postpartum Visitor*, which is the inverse direction. That book is for the people you need to keep out. This one is for the people you need to let in.

With care, Maya

Chapter 1: Why Asking Is Harder Than Saying No

Saying no is hard for postpartum reasons. Asking is hard for older reasons.

Most adults have spent decades practicing self-sufficiency. The career. The household. The keeping-it-together. The ability to figure out the answer alone is, by mid-adulthood, a personality trait. Asking for help collides with that identity in a way saying no does not.

There are also more specific costs. Asking risks rejection. Asking risks getting the wrong help. Asking can feel like admitting you are not handling it. Asking can feel like an imposition on people whose own lives are full. So most people who need help do not ask. They white-knuckle through. They wait for someone to offer. They are quietly grateful when help arrives and quietly resentful when it doesn't.

The system has a name for this and it does not work.

What works is the opposite. A specific ask. A specific person. A specific time. An easy exit for them if it does not work. Most adults will say yes to a good ask. The reason they do not currently say yes is that you have not given them a good ask.

This book gives you the asks. Thirty scripts across eight categories. The asks are short on purpose. The bones are here. You will modify them to sound like you.

A small principle: ask early. Ask before you collapse. The version of you that asks at week four is asking from a stronger position than the version of you that finally asks at week eight after a meltdown. Asking is preventive maintenance. By the time it is emergency repair, the cost has already been paid.

Chapter 2: The Structure of a Good Ask

Every script in this book follows the same four-part structure. If you remember nothing else from the book, remember these four parts. With them, you can write your own scripts for situations the book does not cover.

1. Specific person. Not "anyone." Not "the group chat." A specific person, by name. The act of picking one person is the act of taking the ask seriously.

2. Specific request. Not "help." A specific thing. "Could you bring dinner Thursday." "Could you watch the baby for one hour Tuesday afternoon." "Could you come sit with me Saturday morning."

3. Specific time. A date or a time window. Not "sometime soon." "This Thursday around 6pm." "Tuesday between 2 and 3pm." "Saturday at 10am."

4. Easy exit. A clause that makes "no" comfortable for them. "Totally fine if you cannot." "No worries if you have other plans." "If this doesn't work, no pressure at all."

The fourth part is the one most askers skip. It feels weird to invite a no. But the easy exit is the move that protects the relationship. It signals that the ask is not a test, that their no is allowed, that you can both move on without injury. Friendships survive bad asks when the asker leaves room for no.

Every script in this book follows this structure. Read them once. Then write your own.

Chapter 3: Meals

The most common kind of help. Also the most useful.

A meal dropped at the door is the closest thing to free time the postpartum person, the caregiver, the new-parent household, or the recovering-from-surgery friend ever gets. Twenty minutes that were going to be spent cooking become twenty minutes that can be spent doing literally anything else.

The trick is not to wait until someone offers. The asker initiates. You name a friend, a family member, a coworker. You say what you would actually like. You give them a date. You give them an out.

A second principle: when in doubt, ask for groceries instead of a cooked meal. A friend who is overwhelmed can still hit a store. A friend who cannot cook can still send a meal-delivery subscription. The form of the help is yours to choose. You do not have to receive home-cooked.

SCRIPT 1, MEAL DROP-OFF TO A FRIEND

Hi [name], I am still getting our footing here in the early weeks with the baby. Would you be able to drop off a meal sometime this week? Any night between [date] and [date] would be great. Even a takeout pickup at your favorite spot would be amazing. No pressure if this doesn't work.

SCRIPT 2, MEAL DROP-OFF TO A FAMILY MEMBER

Mom / [name], I need a hand with dinners this week. Could you bring something Thursday around 6? If you're up for it, dinner would help us so much. No need to stay long, we just need food that we did not have to cook.

SCRIPT 3, MEAL-TRAIN COORDINATION

Hi [name], would you be willing to set up a small meal-train link for us? We don't want a huge production. Maybe a meal every other day for two weeks. I'll send you the list of who to invite if you are open to it. If this is too much to coordinate, no pressure, I'll figure something else out.

SCRIPT 4, GROCERY RUN

[Name], I'm at the point where the grocery run is the thing I can't quite manage. Would you be willing to pick up a list for me this week? I'll Venmo you for everything. Could mean a lot of help, no pressure if it doesn't work.

SCRIPT 5, PROFESSIONAL DELIVERY

[Name], I know this is random, but is there a chance I could ask you to send us a few weeks of grocery delivery or meal-kit subscription as our baby gift? It would be the best gift in the world right now. Of course if not, no pressure at all.

Chapter 4: Childcare

For the parent of small kids, an hour of childcare is gold. A morning is a sabbath. An overnight is a different life.

Most people in your circle have not figured out how to offer this without being asked. They are not bad people. They just do not know what would help. The ask gives them a job to say yes to.

A small caveat for this chapter: the easier the ask, the more likely the yes. "Watch the kid for an hour while they nap" is an easier yes than "watch the kid for a whole afternoon at the playground." Start with the easy ones. Build the muscle.

SCRIPT 6, ONE HOUR FOR A PARENT'S OWN APPOINTMENT

[Name], I have a doctor's appointment Tuesday at 2pm. Could you come over and be with [baby] for one hour, 1:45 to 2:45? They will probably nap most of that time. I'll have everything set up. Totally fine if you can't.

SCRIPT 7, MORNING FOR A REST

Mom / [name], could you come over Saturday morning, say 9 to 11, and just hold [baby] / be with [older kid] while I sleep? No need to do anything. Just be there with them. This would help more than you know.

SCRIPT 8, KID PICK-UP FROM SCHOOL OR DAYCARE

[Name], something came up and I need to be at [appointment] Thursday afternoon. Would you be able to pick [kid] up from [school / daycare] at 3pm and keep them for an hour or two until I can get there? I'll write [school] to add you to the pickup list. No worries if not.

SCRIPT 9, AN HOUR FOR A SHOWER

[Name], this is small but real, I haven't showered in three days. Could you come over for one hour [day] so I can

shower, eat something, and breathe? I am not asking you to do anything except be in the house with me.

SCRIPT 10, OVERNIGHT (FOR THE BRAVE ASK)

[Name], I am wondering if you would be open to keeping [older kid] overnight on [date]. [Partner] and I really need one stretch of sleep. They have school the next morning so they would just need their backpack and breakfast. Completely understand if this is too much to ask.

Chapter 5: Eldercare

For the adult child caring for an aging parent, the help question is layered. The person you are caring for is often resistant to other helpers. The siblings are often inconsistent. The friends do not know what to offer because they have not been here yet.

The scripts in this chapter are short. The eldercare ask works best when it is one specific thing for one specific stretch. A day. A weekend. An appointment. Not "help out more in general."

SCRIPT 11, COMPANY FOR THE PARENT FOR AN AFTERNOON

[Sibling name], could you spend the afternoon with Mom / Dad on [date]? I have not had a day off in weeks. I'd be so grateful if you could be there from say 11 to 4. They would love to see you. Let me know if that works.

SCRIPT 12, TAKING OVER FOR A WEEKEND

[Sibling], I am asking for a real weekend off. Could you take over for the weekend of [date]? You don't have to be at the house the whole time, but you would be the primary point of contact for any issues with Mom / Dad, including any calls from the facility / home aide. Two days. I need a real break.

SCRIPT 13, ACCOMPANYING TO AN APPOINTMENT

[Name], Mom has an appointment with [specialist] on [date] at [time]. Could you come with us? I need a second pair of ears in the room, and someone who can drive home if I am too rattled by what they tell us.

Chapter 6: Errands

The small daily logistics that pile up. The pharmacy. The dry cleaner. The package pickup. The drive to the airport. None of them is a big ask. All of them add up.

The errand ask is the most underused category. People often think "I do not want to bother them with something so small." That logic gets it exactly backward. Small asks are the EASIEST yeses. They build the asking muscle. They let the relationship know that asking is okay.

Ask for small things. The big things become easier.

SCRIPT 14, PHARMACY OR PICKUP

[Name], could you grab a [prescription / package / dry cleaning] for me this week? It's just at [location]. I'll Venmo you for any pickup fee. Totally fine if you can't.

SCRIPT 15, RIDE TO AN APPOINTMENT

[Name], I have an appointment [date] at [time] across town. Could you drive me? I don't think I should drive home after. I'll buy you coffee on the way. No worries if you're busy.

SCRIPT 16, AN AIRPORT RUN

[Name], I have to get to the airport at [time] on [date]. Any chance you can drive me / pick me up? I know it's a lift, no pressure at all if not.

Chapter 7: Emotional Support

When you need a person, not a task.

This is the hardest chapter for most people. The emotional ask feels like an imposition because it does not come with a clear job. The person you ask is not bringing food, not running an errand, not watching a kid. They are just being present.

The truth: most people you would consider asking for this are honored to be asked. The "I am bothering them" worry is yours, not theirs. They want to be useful. They do not always know how. You giving them a specific way to be present is a gift to them as much as it is help for you.

A note: if you are struggling in a way that is bigger than a friend can hold, a therapist is a different type of ask. Asking for help includes asking for professional help when the weight is larger than any friend ought to handle. Crisis lines in the US: 988. UK: 116 123. Canada: 9-8-8.

SCRIPT 17, JUST TALKING ON THE PHONE

[Name], I am having a hard week. Could you call me sometime in the next day or two and just let me talk? You don't have to fix anything. I just need to hear your voice.

SCRIPT 18, A VISIT WHERE YOU DO NOTHING TOGETHER

[Name], could you come over [day] and just be here? We don't need to do anything. We can sit on the couch. We can fold laundry. I am tired of being alone with my own thoughts.

SCRIPT 19, A WALK

[Name], could we walk [date] at [time]? An hour, somewhere we both like. I just need to be outside with another adult for a bit.

SCRIPT 20, A CRY OVER TEA

[Name], I am not okay. Can I come over [time] and cry over tea? You don't have to do anything. I just need to be near you for a bit.

Chapter 8: Money

The hardest ask category. Even the scripts here come with a note: financial professionals exist, and they are often a kinder route than asking family and friends.

A loan between people is also a different shape than other asks. It deserves to be in writing. It deserves a clear repayment schedule. It deserves a path for what happens if the repayment hits a snag. The friendship between an asker and a lender is most likely to survive when the loan is treated like a real instrument, not a vague favor.

A second principle: ask the right person, not the first person. The right person is one who can afford the loan without losing sleep over whether you repay. The wrong person is anyone for whom your loan would be a meaningful chunk of their own security. Asking the wrong person can hurt them and the relationship even if they say yes.

SCRIPT 21, ASKING A FAMILY MEMBER FOR A LOAN

[Name], I am in a tight spot and would like to ask you for a short-term loan. I am looking for \$[amount], to be repaid by [date] on [terms]. I would like to put this in writing so it's clear for both of us. I will completely understand if this is not possible. I want to ask in a way that respects our relationship either way.

SCRIPT 22, ASKING A FRIEND TO COVER A SHARED EXPENSE TEMPORARILY

[Name], I am cash-flow tight right now. Could you cover my half of [shared expense] this month? I'll pay you back by [date]. Totally fine if not, I'll figure it out otherwise.

SCRIPT 23, ASKING FOR HELP FROM A PROFESSIONAL OR EMPLOYER

[Name / HR], I am dealing with a temporary financial strain and wanted to ask if [the company] has any short-term assistance, advance, or hardship programs available. Even pointing me to the right resource would help.

A note: before asking family or friends for money, consider whether a financial planner, a credit-counseling service, or a social worker could help you see options you might not know exist. Money asks between individuals can strain relationships. The professional route is sometimes kinder.

Chapter 9: Home Help

Cleaning, repairs, lawn, the things that build up.

These scripts work especially well when paired with food. "Come help me clean for two hours and I will buy lunch" is more attractive than "come help me clean for two hours." The reciprocity makes the ask easier to accept.

SCRIPT 24, A HOUSE-CLEANING HAND

[Name], could you help me deep-clean the house [day]? Even just two hours together. I'll make us lunch after. I need company, not a magic act.

SCRIPT 25, A SMALL REPAIR

[Name], I know you're handy. Would you be willing to come help me with [specific repair: a leaky faucet, a curtain rod, hanging shelves] sometime in the next two weeks? I'll cover the parts and feed you afterward.

SCRIPT 26, LAUNDRY HELP

[Name], any chance you could come over Saturday and help me get through the laundry pile? It's gotten out of hand. We can do it together. I'll provide snacks.

SCRIPT 27, ORGANIZING A ROOM

[Name], I want to attack [the kid's closet / the garage / the pantry] this month and I would not get it done alone. Could you spend an afternoon with me on it? Sunday or Saturday.

Chapter 10: Visits

The "just come over" ask. The simplest category. Also the most under-asked.

A friend at your house, doing nothing, is the kind of help that does not look like help on a spreadsheet. It looks like a hangout. The cost to them is low. The value to you, on a hard week, is enormous. Most adults default to "I will not bother them" when they should default to "I will text them right now."

SCRIPT 28, COMING OVER WITHOUT EXPECTATIONS

[Name], can you come over [day] and hang out for a few hours? I do not want to leave the house. We can watch a movie / sit on the porch / drink coffee. Bring nothing. Just come.

SCRIPT 29, A VIDEO CALL

[Name], could we do a video call this week? I miss seeing your face. Even half an hour would help. Tell me what works for you.

SCRIPT 30, "WILL YOU SIT WITH ME"

[Name], I am not feeling great. Will you come over and sit with me for an hour? You don't have to talk.

A reminder: the thirty scripts are templates. Edit freely. The number of people who will say yes is higher than you think. The number who will say no is also real and does not mean anything about you or about them.



Chapter 11: When They Say No

Sometimes the answer will be no. That has to be okay, or asking does not work.

What to say back when someone declines:

- "Totally understood, thank you for letting me know."
- "No worries at all, I appreciate you considering it."
- "I get it, thanks for being honest."

What not to say:

- "Are you sure?" (Pressures them.)
- "It's fine, I'll just do it myself." (Guilt-trippy.)
- "I just thought you would want to help." (Manipulative.)

When multiple people say no. That is information, not a verdict. Sometimes it means your network is stretched thin (their lives are also hard). Sometimes you need a different network for this kind of help. Sometimes you need a paid version (a postpartum doula, a respite worker, a cleaner, a meal-delivery service).

When no one to ask comes to mind. That is its own data. Worth talking to a therapist or social worker about. Isolation is a real problem, and there are services designed for people without local networks.

A reminder for either case: paid help is help. It is not a failure of your network. It is a different tool.

Chapter 12: When They Say Yes

The "yes" needs to be received well so they can do it again.

What to say back:

- "Oh, thank you. This is going to help so much."
- "I really appreciate it. [Specific thing: I'll see you Thursday at 6, no need to bring anything else]."
- "This is the kindest thing. Truly."

What to make easy for them:

- Tell them exactly where to be and when.
- If they're bringing food, tell them what counts as a successful meal in your house. They will guess wrong otherwise.
- If they're watching the kid, leave a one-page note with what the kid eats, naps, calms with, gets scared of.
- If they're running an errand, send the list with quantities and brands you trust.

The friend who feels successful doing one ask is the friend who says yes to the next ask.

What to not do:

- Do not change your mind at the last minute unless something genuinely came up. The friend who arrived to find you "all set" after preparing for two hours will be less available next time.
- Do not over-apologize while they are there. Apologizing twenty times for "putting them out" makes them feel awkward. One thank-you at the start, one at the end, in between just be present.

Thank-you after:

- A text the next day with one specific thank-you.
- A small handwritten note for the bigger asks.
- A small reciprocal favor when you are back on your feet.

The goal is not scorekeeping. The goal is a relationship that can hold mutual help over a lifetime.

Chapter 13: The Thank-You Script Library

For when the help has happened.

Text, next-day thank-you:

*Hey, just wanted to say thank you again for [specific thing].
It really helped. I owe you one.*

Text, a week later:

*Still thinking about how much your [help] meant. Thank
you.*

Written note, for bigger help:

Dear [name],

*I want you to know what you did meant more than I could
say in the moment. [One specific detail of the help they
gave.] I will not forget it.*

With love and thanks, [your name]

Voice note or call, for the biggest help. Sometimes the right thank-you is your voice. Not a text. Tell them.

A small repay gift, when ready:

- A meal you make for them later.
- A book you know they will love.
- Childcare for them when their season turns hard.
- Something specific to the kind of help they gave.

The most important repay is this: the next time this person says yes to help you, say yes back when they need you. The reciprocity is what turns a favor into a relationship.

Chapter 14: A Last Note

You asked.

That is the hardest part. Not the receiving of help. Not the thanking afterward. The asking.

You did the thing that people who do not ask never do. You named a need to another person. You gave them the dignity of being asked. That is its own gift to them, even if they said no.

The next time will be slightly easier. The time after that, slightly more.

The thirty scripts are templates. The way you use them is yours. The relationships you build with these asks will outlast this season.

You are not alone, even when the work feels like it. The asking is the bridge.

With care, Maya



About Soothemade

Soothemade is a small apothecary of printables, planners, cards, and books for new parents and the people taking care of them.

The books exist for the moments when a journal does not fit the need. When you want to read, not write. When you are looking up the chapter at 3am on your phone, not pulling a printed page out of a drawer.

Each book is adapted from a Soothemade printable. The printable contains writing space and prompts. The book contains the reading. Both work. Some readers want one, some want the other, some want both.

Also from Soothemade

The printable companion to this book is **The Asking for Help Script Pack**, available at notes.soothemade.com. The scripts and templates are the same.

The inverse direction has its own book: **30 Scripts for the Postpartum Visitor**. That book is for the people you need to keep out. This one is for the people you need to let in. They pair.

Other Soothemade products that pair with this book:

- **The Visitor Welcome Packet**, the printable for when you have started saying yes to visitors. Ground rules, food drop menu, "how to help" list.
 - **The Eldercare First 90 Days Planner**, where the asking-for-help muscle gets a serious workout.
 - **The Family Caregiver Workbook**, the long-haul companion.
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Crisis lines

If you are struggling in a way that is bigger than asking a friend, the lines below are open.

United States

- 988, Suicide and Crisis Lifeline (call or text)
- 1-833-852-6262, Postpartum Support International HelpLine
- 1-833-943-5746, Maternal Mental Health Hotline

United Kingdom

- 116 123, Samaritans

Canada

- 9-8-8, Suicide Crisis Helpline

Australia

- 1300 726 306, PANDA

Asking for help is not a sign that something is wrong with you. It is a sign that you are paying attention.

This book is for planning and personal use only. It is not legal, financial, medical, or psychological advice.

A Soothemade book. Made slowly, in plain language.